

History & Folklore Barley has been consumed for many thousands of years. Dioscorides (1st century CE) recommended it “to weaken and restrain all sharp and subtle humours, and sore and ulcerated throats.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses An excellent food for convalescence in the form of porridge or barley water, barley is soothing to the throat and provides easily assimilated nutrients. It can also be taken to clear mucus. Its demulcent quality soothes inflammation of the gut and urinary tract. Barley aids in the digestion of milk and is given to babies to prevent the development of curds within the stomach. It is commonly given to children suffering from minor infections or diarrhea, and it is particularly recommended as a treatment for feverish states. Made into a poultice, barley is an effective remedy for soothing and reducing inflammation in sores and swellings.

Research The fiber in barley, like that in oats, has an established action in reducing fat absorption from the gut, aiding lower cholesterol levels. In common with other fiber foods, it may also help to stabilize blood sugar levels and to prevent bowel cancer.

Hydrangea arborescens (Hydrangeaceae)

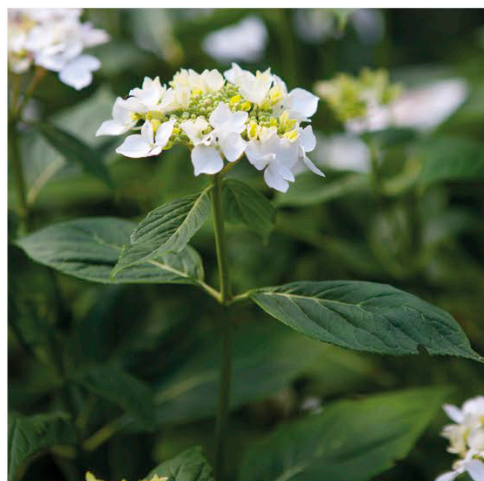
Wild Hydrangea

Description Woody-stemmed deciduous shrub growing to a height of about 10 ft (3 m). Has oval leaves and clusters of small, creamy-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the eastern U.S. from New York to Florida, wild hydrangea grows in woodlands and on riverbanks. The root is dug up in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Hydrangea is thought to contain flavonoids, a cyanogenic glycoside (hydrangein), saponins, and a volatile oil.



Wild hydrangea is used to treat kidney and bladder stones.

History & Folklore The Cherokee used hydrangea as a remedy for kidney and bladder stones. The 19th-century Physiomedicalist herbal movement used a formula comprising hydrangea, couch grass (*Agropyron repens*, p. 162), and hollyhock (*Althaea rosea*) to treat serious kidney disorders, including nephritis.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Western herbal medicine considers the diuretic hydrangea as being particularly helpful in the treatment of kidney and bladder stones. It is thought both to encourage the expulsion of stones and to help dissolve those that remain. The herb is given for many other troubles affecting the genitourinary system, including cystitis, urethritis, enlarged prostate, and prostatitis.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding. Wild hydrangea is best taken on professional advice.

Hygrophila spinosa (Acanthaceae)

Gokulakanta

Description Thorny, red-stemmed annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has bright blue flowers and small, flat, dark red seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India, gokulakanta is now widely distributed throughout tropical regions. It is gathered when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Gokulakanta contains mucilage, fixed and volatile oils, and an alkaloid.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Commonly used as a remedy in India, gokulakanta is taken chiefly for its reputed aphrodisiac properties. Both the aerial parts and ash of the burned plant are strongly diuretic, and are used to flush water from the body in cases of excess fluid retention.

Related Species The South American *H. guayensis* is bactericidal and has been used as a local treatment for the tropical disease, leishmaniasis.

Hyoscyamus niger (Solanaceae) Henbane

Description Annual or biennial herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has delicate, slightly lobed leaves and bell-shaped flowers, pale yellow in color with fine purple veining.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western Asia and southern Europe, henbane is now found across much of western and central Europe, and North and South America. It is cultivated for

therapeutic use in parts of Europe, including England, and in North America. The leaves and flowers are picked just after the plant has flowered, in the first year for the annual variety and in the second year for the biennial.

Parts Used Leaves, flowering tops.

Constituents Henbane contains 0.045–0.14% tropane alkaloids, especially hyoscyamine and hyoscyne, and flavonoids. Hyoscyamine and hyoscyne are common to other members of the *Solanaceae* family, but henbane's relatively high hyoscyne content gives it a more specifically sedative action than its relatives thornapple (*Datura stramonium*, p. 200) and deadly nightshade (*Atropa belladonna*, p. 69).

History & Folklore Henbane has been used as a medicinal herb for thousands of years. Babylonian accounts and the Egyptian Ebers papyrus (c. 1500 BCE) record that henbane was smoked to relieve toothache. In Greek myth, the dead were adorned with henbane when they arrived in Hades. Writing in the 1st century CE, Dioscorides recommended henbane for insomnia, coughs, congestion, heavy menstrual bleeding, eye pain, gout, and as a general pain reliever; and advised that the herb should be used within a year as it deteriorates quickly. In the Middle Ages, henbane had the Latin name *dentaria*, denoting its use as a remedy against toothache. Henbane reputedly produces a sensation of lightness, as though one were flying, and it was one of the chief components of witches' "flying ointments."



Henbane has distinctive yellow flowers veined with purple. The plant was used in classical times as a general painkiller.